

Bhilai helped her quickly adapt to the multicultural organisation. “Bokaro and Bhilai were very cosmopolitan for their time. We looked out for each other as everyone was working in the same place. Everyone, from the children of the managing director to [those of] the most junior employee studied in the same class in the project school in Bhilai,” she says.

However, there was a time when she was almost on the verge of quitting SBI. This happened when she was asked to relocate to Lucknow and she wasn't too sure about finding a good school for her daughter. She consulted one of her mentors, M.S. Verma—a former SBI chairman who went on to head telecom regulator Trai—who famously told her, “It takes only about 30 seconds to let go and resign. Take up the posting and find out if there is a suitable school available in the new city. You have worked hard and are just about beginning to taste success.” Taking his advice, she shifted to Lucknow and was soon able to find the right school for her daughter.

Bhattacharya agrees that she has always been blessed with the right mentors. “Luck did play a part in putting me in the right place at the right time.” Other than Verma, she has also been inspired by anecdotes from the life of another SBI chairman, Raj Kumar Talwar, recounted to her by senior colleagues. Calling him a giant in Indian banking, she remains fascinated by the way he would conduct the business.

CHILDHOOD LESSONS

She is also known to be an effective communicator and teacher. She credits this to her meeting theatre director Amalendu Chatterjee in the sixth standard. “He taught me how to enunciate so that each word could be understood. The fact that I used to act in plays during every vacation helped me get rid of stage

fear.” Right from her school days, she was encouraged by her teachers to take part in debates, which again provided her exposure to public speaking. “I do a far better job impromptu than reading from a script,” she says.

This quality of hers is widely admired by her peers in the industry. “Arundhati's frank and earthy approach and articulation of issues has always struck a chord with business and banking audiences,” says Romesh Sobti, former MD & CEO of IndusInd Bank and last year's winner of the Lifetime Achievement Award.

Bhattacharya is also a votary of a less-cash society. She says that India's large cash economy, described by many as a black economy, doesn't benefit those taking part in

banks tying up with technology companies as well as fintechs.

She firmly believes that despite all the challenges that may emerge, SBI will continue to grow in strength. “Unlike the belief that the public sector is stodgy and can't move fast, there are ways and means of getting these things done. If somebody wants to set a target and a vision, that can happen.”

She is also a strong supporter of giving back to society. “While we were young, it was not told to us in so many words. It was more important to keep our heads above water. Among Generation Z, those who aren't pressed for financial security, [they] need to practice giving back. It's difficult to get satisfaction otherwise,” she says. One of the reasons that helped her make

“AN ABILITY TO BUILD CONSENSUS, CARRY THE TEAM ALONG AND A PLEASANT PERSONALITY MAKE ARUNDHATI A VERY CAPABLE LEADER” SAYS RAJNISH KUMAR, FORMER SBI CHAIRMAN

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it. “That is mainly because several small players, while avoiding taxes, aren't allowing themselves to build up a credit history that will enable them to leverage more resources to grow their businesses.” In her view, the immediate gratification derived from not parting with taxes doesn't enable growth.

While she sees a highly collaborative future for the banking industry, Bhattacharya rules out the possibility of lenders turning into tech companies. “At the end of the day, you are a bank. You need to think of the customer and processes. If you become a tech company, then banking will become a secondary activity. And that's not what you are.” She, therefore, sees

up her mind on joining Salesforce after a meeting with Founder Marc Benioff was the company's focus on philanthropy, particularly its work for the rehabilitation of the homeless in the US.

So, what's next on the cards for a banker who had once considered a career in journalism? “I regret not getting there [journalism],” she says wistfully. Maybe a new book and submission of a thesis in financial inclusion to fulfil a long-held dream of completing a PhD.

The granite statue of Lord Buddha on the wall behind her table appears to be meditating in silent approval. **BT**

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